

Chapter 131_2 - Following

The small city was very small, not even half the size of Point Star Town¹. Built against the mountains, most buildings were earthen houses that cleverly merged with the rocks. When walking through the city, one often looked up to see mountains.

Most of the people wrapped their heads and faces with headcloths to avoid the scorching sunlight. Their clothing was mainly gray and black, all sewn from coarse cloth.

After she entered the city, the sky finally dimmed. The moon rose above the rooftops, and most of the city's household doors had already closed early, leaving only some people hurrying home.

She had wanted to find a place to rest in the city, but after walking around without seeing an inn, she decided to rest outside the city. However, just as she turned around, she saw a woman in gray clothes and a floral headscarf standing not far away, looking at her.

Behind the woman was a child with lamb-horn braids². Though her face was red and black from the sun, her eyes were surprisingly bright as she hid behind the woman, timidly peeking out her head.

"Miss, did you come through the great desert?" The woman's smile revealed white teeth. Perhaps because her cheeks were full of weathering, her teeth appeared even whiter and brighter.

Ning Fuyi nodded.

The woman's gaze swept over the dust on Ning Fuyi's body, shaking her head in amazement: "These years, few people dare to walk this way. As far as the eye can see, it's all dirt mounds, and the wind is strong. Who knows how many dead people are buried in that sand!"

"Miss must have suffered greatly crossing that desert." The woman pointed behind herself. "At the end of this road is my home. If you don't mind this rough woman's clumsy hands, you can stay the night."

"Then I'm much obliged." Ning Fuyi hurriedly bowed her head in thanks.

"It's nothing." The woman waved at her, then took the child's hand and led the way. "This place is called Mengguan³. In the past, the surrounding areas were prosperous, and it was quite a strategic location. But later, most of those cities were buried under yellow sand, leaving only this bit of territory."

"Where are you from, miss, and where are you going?" The woman seemed like she hadn't seen outsiders in a long time and was quite enthusiastic.

"From..." Ning Fuyi licked her lips. "The west, just happened to pass through here."

Hearing her evasive words, the woman knew she was deliberately concealing something, but didn't press the matter. She laughed heartily: "That's fine too. When young ladies travel outside, it's good to be cautious."

Ning Fuyi smiled: "My surname is Ning."

"My surname is Luo. Just call me Aunt Luo. This is my daughter, named Yuange'er⁴." The woman patted the child. "Come, greet the lady."

"Sister Ning." Yuange'er spoke in a sweet, childish voice. Unlike the woman's hearty manner, she was shy and hid in the woman's robes.

"Hello." Ning Fuyi's mood improved a bit as she waved at her.

"Here we are." The woman stopped in front of an earthen wall, pushed open the door and entered. Though there was no greenery or decorations inside, it was swept clean, with a wooden cradle thrown in the corner.

"My husband passed away, so this room has always been empty. I clean it every day—it's very clean." The woman busily brought clean cotton quilts.

Seeing her lowering her head to make the bed, Ning Fuyi quickly reached out to stop her: "I can do it myself. It's getting late—you should rest."

"Oh my, it's rare to see outsiders in this dusty place—we can't be negligent!" The woman insisted on making the bed properly, then picked up some firewood from the corner and went into the adjacent earthen house. "There's no food in the great desert—you must be starving."

"Our family is poor and has no chicken, duck, or fish, but I can make you a bowl of saozhi noodles⁵. Don't worry—my noodles can be smelled ten li⁶ around for their fragrance!" The woman cheerfully poked her head out, then withdrew it again.

Soon, cooking smoke rose high into the night sky. The smell of smoke and oil entered her nostrils and traveled through her breath into her lungs.

Ning Fuyi smiled slightly, slowly squatted down, and beckoned to Yuange'er, who was standing shyly to the side. Yuange'er hesitated for a while before slowly walking over.

"How old are you?" Ning Fuyi smiled gently.

Yuange'er held up five short fingers, then pulled them back.

"So young." Ning Fuyi smiled softly and gently. "Why are you called Yuange'er?"

This time the girl spoke, drawing out her voice: "Because Mama says she wants me to be like the birds in the sky, free and unrestrained."

Free and unrestrained. Ning Fuyi felt somewhat dazed. She remembered Ning Changfeng had also said such words, so she reached out to hug the girl, then let go.

Yuange'er was very obedient. Her small body was held in the embrace without struggling at all.

"Do you want to grow up?" Ning Fuyi asked again.

Yuange'er shook her head, then suddenly remembered something and nodded vigorously, her lamb-horn braids swaying: "I do. Mama says living is tiring, and chopping wood is tiring too. I want to grow up quickly so I can help her chop wood."

Looking at her red little face, Ning Fuyi's heart softened. Yes, for ordinary people, living was already a difficult thing. Even if one held a high position, what right did they have to decide their life and death?

"Yuange'er is so good." Ning Fuyi touched her cleanly combed hair.

Soon, the woman brought the noodles to the table. Red and green vegetable pieces were sprinkled on the distinct hand-pulled noodles, the broth red and thick. Without needing to lean in to smell it, one's mouth would water.

"Thank you, Aunt Luo." Ning Fuyi smiled at her.

"You look like someone from Jiangnan⁷. These noodles have a strong flavor—I don't know if you can get used to them." The woman pushed the steaming noodles toward her and smiled kindly.

Footnotes:

¹ **Point Star Town (点星镇)** - A town mentioned earlier in the story where the characters had previously gathered

² **Lamb-horn braids (羊角辫)** - A traditional Chinese hairstyle for young girls where the hair is braided into two sections that stick up like small horns

³ **Mengguan (蒙关)** - A fictional border town name, literally meaning "Meng Pass" or "Meng Gateway"

⁴ **Yuange'er (鸢鸽儿)** - The child's name, combining "yuan" (kite) and "ge" (dove), with the diminutive "er" suffix common for children's names

⁵ **Saozi noodles (臊子面)** - A traditional Chinese noodle dish with minced meat sauce, popular in northwestern China

⁶ **Li (里)** - A traditional Chinese unit of distance, approximately 500 meters or about a third of a mile

⁷ **Jiangnan (江南)** - Literally "south of the river," referring to the prosperous region south of the Yangtze River, known for its refined culture and beautiful people